

Episode 69: A Little Bit of Promotion! *Theatrical GeGeGe no Kitaro: Japan Explodes!!*

"The sky is high, and I'm getting fat," autumn (crying).

As soon as autumn arrived, my busyness accelerated and late-night work is becoming routine. When you sit and work for long periods, you naturally get hungry, and even if the number of daily meals and amounts don't change, the timing somehow makes one meal fall into late night.

"Late-night meals double the calories!"

These are the words of a certain junior colour director. Ah, truly golden words!! Eating late at night is dangerous!

...While thinking this, I somehow end up eating one meal (crying).

Well, I try to reduce the amount as much as possible at night, but when you sit and work continuously, your brain inevitably craves sugar, and you unconsciously reach for sweets...

Such are these long autumn nights (sobbing).

Well then.

Just recently, a certain producer I know (Producer I) called me...

"Tsujita-san, are you busy right now?"

"Yeah. I'm working on *Theatrical GeGeGe no Kitaro* for December release"

"Huh!? There's such a thing?"

He treated it like "such a thing"! (sobbing)

Theatrical GeGeGe no Kitaro isn't widely known, apparently.

Even though it's almost released...

So out of frustration, I'll do a little promotion this time...

Once again, *Theatrical GeGeGe no Kitaro: Japan Explodes!!*. Nationwide release Saturday, December 20th. Original by Mizuki Shigeru, supervision by Kyogoku Natsuhiko, script by Sanjou Riku, director Koga Gou, character design by Ueno Ken, animation director Asanuma Akihiro, art director Honma Sadaaki, and colour design by me - that's the lineup.

This work and one other job have me extremely busy currently. That's why I've been missing serialisation lately... (deeply reflecting).

The currently airing *Kitaro* TV series is the fourth remake, and apparently this year marks the 40th anniversary since the first series began. That means it gets remade and appears on TV about once every 10 years. Despite everything, it's quite a popular work.

The very first original *Kitaro* was still black and white. I wasn't allowed to watch the original broadcast (I was about 5), but later - I think when I was in middle school? - they reran that original *Kitaro* Sunday mornings at 6 AM during summer, and I remember watching it intently in my darkened room.

A few years before that, I remember watching the second *Kitaro* in evening rerun slots or something. This second series was already in colour, but both the first and second were quite scary.

Then came the 1980s and the third *Kitaro*. Around this time it became more "hero Kitaro" feeling. During this third series, I participated in the theatrical *GeGeGe no Kitaro: The Great Yokai War* (← I wrote about this before, right? (laugh)).

"Never imagined I'd end up working on *Kitaro* that I watched as a child, especially theatrical work" - it was quite a mysterious feeling.

This *GeGeGe no Kitaro: The Great Yokai War* was a story where Yumeko-chan didn't appear. Just between us, I actually disliked Yumeko-chan's existence (explosion). Because the *Kitaro* I'd watched wasn't a justice hero who fought to protect Yumeko-chan (bitter laugh). So when I received the script and storyboard and read through them, I remember feeling somewhat relieved (laugh).

Time flowed further, and the 1990s brought the fourth *Kitaro*. Yes, digital colouring started from this fourth series. While I hardly watched the actual broadcasts, being the first digital colouring work, it was apparently quite difficult. The colour designer then was Itasaka-san, who's also handling the currently acclaimed fifth series.

So the fifth series. And its theatrical feature.

While *Kitaro* has been made into theatrical works many times, they were all about 40-minute short or medium-length films, making this the first 90-minute feature-length anime film adaptation. That was somewhat surprising.

Well, for story details, please check the official website, but this theatrical version is in a way a festival (laugh). What kind of festival? Japan is divided into six regions, with different versions screening in each region - that's the "gimmick."

What's different? When Neko-musume gets blown far away by the demon mirror Kagami-jijii and runs around Japan to return to Kitaro, regional "local specialties" appear for each area.

As reported recently, Higashikokubaru, Governor of Miyazaki, appears as a "local speciality" for the Kyushu-Okinawa region. We properly asked him to do the voice acting (laugh). Also, for the Kanto-Koshinetsu region, Fuji TV's morning information programmes "Mezamashi TV" appears. Again, we had Otsuka announcer, Takashima announcer, and weather presenter Kaito Aiko-san voice themselves!

I created colours for all these "local speciality" characters. Especially Kaito-san's colours were the most energetically created colour direction, and I'm quite pleased with my self-praise of "Really well done! Perfect!" She's my top pick among this theatrical version's characters! The person herself was apparently very pleased too (joy). Ah, I really wanted to meet Kaito-san in person (sobbing).

For *The Great Yokai War*, I stubbornly insisted on "absolutely something different from TV" and worked hard, but for this *Japan Explodes!!*, I'm making it thinking "so people who always watch TV can enjoy it even more." The feeling is to upgrade the TV taste that everyone knows further in the theatrical version.

Well, in that way (← what way?), we're making *Theatrical GeGeGe no Kitaro: Japan Explodes!!*. It should be completed soon (probably). Please look forward to it!

Producer I should definitely go see it properly at the theatres!

And the story about that other job next time.

(08.11.04)

